

87 Shifting focus

"It" clauses, "what" clauses, or moving a noun to the front of a sentence can all be used to put emphasis on a certain word or phrase.

See also:

Types of verbs **49** Defining relative clauses **81**

Non-defining relative clauses **82**

87.1 FOCUSING WITH "IT" CLAUSES

Part of a sentence can be emphasized by adding "it is" or "it was" before it, and "that" after it. This can correct a misunderstanding or emphasize something unexpected.

You've met my friend John before, haven't you?



This stresses that it wasn't John who I met before.

"That" is added before the main verb.

No, **it was your friend Michael that** I met.

"It is" or "it was" is added before the noun phrase to be focused.

"Your friend Michael" is now the focus of the sentence.

The main verb moves to the end.

FURTHER EXAMPLES

The second clause is a relative clause. It is most commonly introduced by "that," "which," or "who." "When" and "where" can also be used, but they're less formal.

It is the engine that I need to replace.



It was summertime when Zoe last saw her cousins.



It was the doctor who I needed to call.



It was in a bar where Olly first met his wife.



It was the cold weather which made me sick.



It was the price which changed my mind.



It was my colleague who prepared the food.



It was the toaster that set off the fire alarm.

